case, I have something to tell you.' He went on to add that he was stepping down and proposing that Ratan be appointed as chairman in his place. When the moment came, it did take Ratan by surprise.

Then came another caveat, this time more perplexing: JRD said that he would have to consult Ajit Kerkar first. Ratan blurted out, 'Why Kerkar?' JRD replied that he desired the advice of a Hindu to choose the most auspicious day for the momentous transfer of power. Accordingly, Monday, 25 March, was fixed for the board meeting where Ratan's appointment would be confirmed.

The Dawn of a New Era

The setting was Bombay House. The boardroom of Tata Sons Limited, on the fourth floor, was chosen to bear witness to the last of the most important decisions of the century for the group.

The last board meeting of Tata Sons that JRD would chair began on the dot at a quarter past ten in the morning. Soon after the confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting, agenda item two, 'To consider the Letter from Mr JRD Tata' was taken up. It was JRD's letter of resignation and his proposal to appoint Ratan Naval Tata in his place.

'I have put in a long tenure of fifty-three years,' said the chairman as the other members listened with rapt attention. 'Now I wish to retire and I would strongly recommend Ratan N. Tata to succeed me.' As if on cue, Pallonji Mistry, who then held 16.3 per cent of the company shares, stood up and seconded the proposal. All the other fifteen directors present expressed their approval. Russi Mody, who was in Calcutta, could not attend the meeting. Thereupon JRD got up and invited Ratan to chair the remaining proceedings. But before the new chairman took the chair, the senior-most director at the meeting, Nani Palkhivala, stood up and expressed, on behalf of his colleagues, 'his deepest gratitude to Mr JRD Tata for his outstanding contribution to [the] Tatas during the past 6 decades'.

An emotional Ratan followed. With 'considerable feeling', he expressed 'his deep sense of gratitude to Mr JRD Tata and the board for the great honour that had been bestowed' on him. He reflected that throughout his twenty-eight years in the Tatas, during which he had experienced great satisfaction and at times some disappointment, 'the single motivating factor